



OpenPantry

Volunteer Handbook

FOR VOLUNTEERS

How to open and run the checkout and Menu Counter stations.

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START HERE

Welcome

Thank you for volunteering! OpenPantry is the software the pantry uses to check food out the door, keep the shelves counted, and know what to reorder. You don't need any technical background — this handbook walks you through opening each station and handling the few moments where the app asks you to do something.

You'll mostly work at one of two stations: the **Scanning Station** (grocery-style checkout with a barcode scanner) or the **Menu Counter** (a tablet where shoppers tap the items they want and volunteers pick the order in back). Both are covered below.

GOLDEN RULE

If anything looks wrong — a frozen screen, a scanner that won't beep, a weight that won't save — **don't force it**. Note the order number if there is one and ask the administrator on duty. Nothing you tap here can break the data.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Getting on the stations

You do **not** need a password to run the scanning station or the Menu Counter. Those screens are locked to the pantry's own network address (its IP), so simply being on the pantry Wi-Fi is what authorizes them — they open straight to the work screen.

- The stations only work while you're on the **pantry's Wi-Fi**. On any other network the app shows an "Access Denied" screen — that's expected, not a login you're missing.
- OpenPantry may also be set to open only during pantry hours. Outside those hours you'll see "Access is closed right now." Try again during service.
- If the pantry's internet address changes, the stations show that same "Access Denied" screen even on the right Wi-Fi. Whoever holds the **supervisor password** can put it right: open **Settings**, and under Secure Network Access press **Use My Current IP** and then **Set IP Address**. That is the one setting a supervisor can change — the rest of the page is read-only for them, so there is nothing to break.
- A password is only requested on **administrator** screens — item setup, Settings, reports, and the delivery client list. Volunteers don't use those day to day; if you land on one by mistake, back out and ask the administrator.

Open-the-Station Checklist — Scanning Station

Work top to bottom. Tick each box as you go.

☐

Power on the Chromebook tablet and connect it to the pantry Wi-Fi (the station only works on the pantry network) if it is not already connected.

☐

Make sure the handheld barcode scanner is connected to the tablet; wait for its ready beep / steady LED.

☐

Power on the produce scale and complete the “PC” setup below if it is not already set.

☐

Open the browser and go to the OpenPantry **Scan** page. It opens straight to the scanner — **no password** is needed, because the pantry network authorizes the station.

☐

Scan any item's barcode as a test — a “Last scan” line should appear. Then tap the red × **Cancel Order** so the test doesn't count.

☐

Tap once inside the barcode box so the cursor sits there (it glows green when focused).

NO WIRED SCANNER? USE THE CAMERA ON THE SAME PAGE

There is one **Scan** page for both ways of scanning. On a phone or any tablet without a handheld scanner, tap **Start Camera** in the *This Order* box and point the camera at the barcode — the page chirps once for each code it reads. **Stop Camera** puts it away. The camera needs permission the first time, and the page must be opened over **https**.

Configuring the produce scale (one-time, each power-on)

The VEVOR scale with RS232 Port connects to the tablet as a USB keyboard. After you power it on it must be switched into “**PC**” mode so it types weights straight into OpenPantry. Do this every time the scale is powered up:

1	Power on the scale and let it settle to 0 .	Zero / stable reading
2	Press the [.] (period / decimal) key.	Enters setup
3	Wait until the display reads “ Entr ”.	Ready for unit
4	Press [2] to set the unit to “ lb ”.	Unit = lb
5	Press [.] (period), then press [9].	Selects PC interface
6	Confirm the weight window shows “ PC ”.	Interfaced to OpenPantry

WHEN YOU SEE “PC”, YOU'RE SET

That reading means the scale is now talking to OpenPantry. You can then weigh produce in **either order** — scan the PLU and set the item on the scale, or weigh it first and scan the PLU when the station asks for it. If the window ever drops back to a plain weight, repeat the steps above: in **print** mode the scale only sends when you press **PRINT**, so weighing first won't work.

CHECKOUT, STEP BY STEP

Running the Scanning Station

Starting and ending an order

- 1 You don't press "start" — the first item you scan automatically opens a new order and assigns it a number (shown large at the top).
- 2 Scan every item the shopper is taking — or add it by name if it won't scan (see below). Each entry drops into the list with a beep.
- 3 When they're done, tap ■ **End Order**. The counts are subtracted from inventory. (You can also scan the special End Order command barcode if your station has one posted.)
- 4 Made a mistake? Tap the red ✕ next to a line to remove that scan, or tap ✕ **Cancel Order** to throw the whole order away.

Adding an item by name (no barcode needed)

No barcode, a barcode that won't scan, or loose produce with no sticker? You can add the item by typing its **name** instead. The entry box is labeled **Barcode or Item Name** — start typing and, after two letters, matching items from the catalog appear beneath it as you type. When your text matches a single item, press **Enter** (or Tab) to record it, exactly as if you'd scanned it. Digits on their own are still treated as a barcode, so typing a name never interferes with the scanner.

FASTEST FIX FOR A TORN OR MISSING BARCODE

If a label is smudged or peeled off, don't hunt for the number — just type the first few letters of the item's name and pick it from the list.

What you don't need to scan

You don't have to capture everything a shopper takes. The scan data drives reordering of the core, regularly-stocked staples, so a few categories can be safely ignored:

- High-calorie items with low nutritional value — e.g. candy, sweets, or desserts.
- Packaged meals and sandwiches.
- Anything that doesn't appear to be regularly stocked — one-off donations and oddments.

If you're unsure whether something is a regularly-stocked staple, ask the administrator.

PRODUCE SOLD BY WEIGHT

Weighing produce — either order

Fruits and vegetables are often sold by weight rather than count, so a produce entry has two halves: the **PLU code** on the sticker and the **weight** from the scale. The station takes them in **either order** — do whichever is quicker with your hands full, and don't tell the app which you're doing. It works it out.

Scan the PLU first

Scan the produce code. A **Weight required** window pops up and the station beeps:

- **Using the scale:** just set the item on the scale. If it's in “PC” mode (see the checklist) the weight fills in by itself — confirm and it saves.
- **By hand:** type 1 digit for pounds, then 2 digits for ounces. Example: typing **514** means **5 lb 14 oz**. Backspace fixes a slip; press **Enter** or **Save Weight**.

Or weigh it first

Set the item on the scale and leave it alone. The scale sends nothing until the reading settles, and then it sends it on its own — you don't press anything. The station catches the weight, beeps, and opens a **Weighed — PLU required** window with the weight shown at the top. (This half needs the scale in “PC” mode — in **print** mode it only sends when you press **PRINT**.)

- 1 Scan the PLU sticker (or type the code and press **Enter**). The weight you already took and the code are saved together as one line.
- 2 Don't know the code? Tap **Type a name instead** and start typing the produce name — only items sold by the pound are offered, so you can't accidentally pick something that would throw the weight away. Pick a match and its PLU is filled in for you.
- 3 Wrong item on the scale, or you'd rather start over? **Discard Weight** throws the reading away and nothing is recorded.

CLEAR THE PLATFORM AFTER EVERY ITEM

Whichever order you use, take the item off the scale and let it return to **0** before the next one. The scale only arms itself to send again once it has been cleared — a platform left loaded is the usual reason a weight “doesn't come through.”

IF SOMETHING LOOKS OFF WITH A WEIGHT

The station protects you from the two mistakes that matter. If the scale is set to **kilograms** (or grams or ounces) it **refuses** the reading and asks you to switch it to **lb**, rather than recording a number that's less than half the real weight. And if the scale sends the same weight twice for one item, the repeat is recognized and ignored — you won't get a duplicate line.

PACKAGED GOODS

When the app doesn't recognize a barcode

Occasionally a packaged item isn't in the catalog. A box appears asking you to **Identify this item**. Type a short, plain generic name (e.g. "Canned Tuna", not the brand) and tap **Save & Record**. The app remembers it for next time. If you're unsure of the name, ask the administrator.

KEEP THE CURSOR IN THE BOX

The scanner types like a keyboard, so the barcode box must stay selected (it glows green). If scans stop registering, tap once inside that box and try again.

Helping on someone else's order (Assist)

On a busy day two volunteers can check the same household out together — one working the wired scanner, one with a phone camera on the other side of the cart. Both sets of scans land in the **same order**, so the shopper is counted once.

Joining an order

- 1 Open the **Scan** page on your device. If another station already has an order going, a card appears titled **Another station is scanning**, listing the order number, when it started, and how many items are on it so far.
- 2 Tap **+ Assist** on the order you're helping with. The top of your screen changes from *Current Order* to **Assisting Order #...**
- 3 Scan normally. Everything you scan goes onto the shared order, and each screen shows the other's items within a couple of seconds — no refreshing.
- 4 When you're done helping, tap **Leave Assist**. You don't have to: when the other volunteer ends the order, your station returns to idle by itself.

Who ends the order

The station that **started** the order owns it. Only that screen has **End Order** and **Cancel Order**; a helper sees **Leave Assist** in their place. That's deliberate — it keeps two people from closing the same shopper out twice, and stops a helper cancelling an order that isn't theirs. If you're helping and the shopper is finished, tell the volunteer who started it.

- The starting station shows a “**1 assisting**” tag while you're helping, so they know you're on it.
- Once two stations share an order, a **Who** column appears in the item list. Your own scans carry a filled badge, your teammate's an outlined one. On a single station the column stays hidden.
- **Either** of you can remove a mis-scan with the red ✕ — including a line the other person entered.

YOU CAN'T ASSIST WITH YOUR OWN ORDER OPEN

If your station already has an order going, finish it first — the app will say “*End this station's own order before assisting another.*” The Assist card only appears on a station that is idle, and a pantry running a single scanner never sees it at all.

CUSTOMER ORDERING KIOSK

Open-the-Station Checklist — Menu Counter

The Menu Counter has two screens: the **customer order form** that shoppers tap, and the **pick queue** that volunteers pull from in the back.

Customer-facing tablet

- ☐ Power on the customer tablet and connect it to the pantry Wi-Fi.
- ☐ Open the browser to the OpenPantry **Menu Counter** order form. It opens directly — **no password** to enter.
- ☐ Confirm the page loads the item buttons grouped by category (Dairy, Dry Goods, Frozen, ...).
- ☐ Set the language selector back to English so the next shopper starts fresh.
- ☐ Stand the tablet in its holder facing the shopper; clean the screen.

Pick-queue tablet / screen (back of house)

- ☐ Open the **Menu Counter** → **Orders** (pick queue) page on the volunteer screen. It opens directly — **no password** needed.
- ☐ Confirm the queue auto-refreshes and the topbar shows “pending orders” and “items remaining”.
- ☐ Submit one test order from the customer tablet and confirm it appears in the queue, then Mark Complete to clear it.
- ☐ Make sure bags/bins and a pen are staged at the pick bench.

NO LOGIN ON THE PANTRY NETWORK

The Menu Counter order form and pick queue are secured by the pantry's network address, not a password, so volunteers never log in to use them. A password is only asked for on the administrator's **item-setup** screen — leave that to the person opening the pantry.

ORDERS & PICKING

Running the Menu Counter

Helping a shopper at the order form

- Shoppers tap the food items they want; selected items highlight. Items marked unavailable show but can't be picked.
- Besides entering their first name, they enter how many adults and children are in the household — the app uses that to set quantities automatically.
- Some items ask for a size (e.g. diapers) — a dropdown appears when the item is selected.

- A translate button lets shoppers switch languages; the form returns to English after each order so the next person starts fresh.
- When they submit, a confirmation appears and the order drops into the pick queue in back.

Picking an order in back

- 1 New orders appear in the queue sidebar with a progress bar. Tap one to open its list.
- 2 Gather each item and tap it to mark it picked (it turns green with a check).
- 3 Use + to add another of an item, or ✕ to remove one that's out of stock or entered accidentally.
- 4 Once every item is checked, tap **Mark Complete** to clear the order from the queue.
- 5 The queue refreshes on its own every 30 seconds — no need to reload.

DELIVERIES & EVENTS

Other channels you may see

Some volunteers help with home **Deliveries** or **Events** (community meals). These use their own simple forms reached from the top menu under **Checkout**. The pattern is the same: pick the items and counts, then submit. A volunteer lead will show you the delivery rotation and printing steps — and remember that client names, addresses, and phone numbers are private (see below).

EVERY SHIFT

Privacy & closing up

Protecting shopper privacy

- Never share or write down a shopper's name, address, or phone number outside the app.
- Don't leave a logged-in tablet unattended where the public can reach the reports.

Closing the station

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Finish or cancel any order still open on the scanning station (the top should read “not started”).

☐

If you were helping another station, tap **Leave Assist** — or make sure the volunteer who started the order has ended it.

☐

Take the last item off the produce scale so it reads **0**.

☐

Clear any leftover orders from the Menu Counter pick queue.

☐

Log out (the **Log out** link, top right) if you're leaving the tablet in a public spot and the admin is signed into the app.

☐

There is no need to power off the equipment, but make sure the tablets are on their chargers.

☐

Tell the administrator about anything odd that happened during the shift.

THANK YOU

Every order you check out becomes data that helps the pantry order smarter and show donors the real need. Your careful scanning literally keeps the shelves stocked.